

Linux certifications from Novell and Red Hat. These promise to give professionals a head start towards their goal of becoming Linux gurus.

Is a Linux certification essential?

Like in any other profession, IT professionals interested in a long-term career in open source need to be able to demonstrate their capabilities. A recognised Linux certification is one measurable way to advertise that prowess. Many job postings today favour applicants with the Novell or Red Hat 'Linux Certified' stamp on their resumes. These certifications are fast becoming pre-requisites for professionals seeking to move up the value chain in the arena of open source.

"Unlike most other industry certifications, Red Hat and Novell certification examinations are hands-on, which makes them a 'serious' option for any professional looking at becoming a Linux expert. Being performance-based certifications, Novell Certified Linux Professional (NCLP) and Red Hat Certified Engineer (RHCE) make a certified candidate the right choice for an employer. The certified employee can be productive from Day One of employment," says Madhav, an RHCE, NCLP and Novell Certified Workload Management Administrator (CWMA).

"Most organisations are shifting to open source operating systems, but some are still hesitant to follow suit because of the lack of support for open source operating systems. Red Hat and Novell certified professionals increase the confidence levels within organisations to shift to open source. It also helps professionals get better jobs and growth opportunities. SUSE enhances your skill sets in Linux such as scripting, GUI, etc, while RHCE gives you the basic skill sets of Linux," adds Sanjeev Bali, an IT professional with a bundle of certifications, including NCLP, RHCE, Novell Certified Linux Engineer (NCLE), Novell Certified Linux Administrator (NCLA) and Certified Novell Instructor for SUSE 10 and 11.

So should it be Red Hat or Novell?

How does one choose the right certification? With Novell and Red Hat being the only two credible Linux certification

choices in India, the search is definitely narrowed down. However, choosing between the two is a tough call. Both have their strengths. Red Hat certification comes with high market value, growth prospects and provides opportunities for further specialisation. Novell holds an equally strong promise for professionals in terms of being easy on the pocket, providing good technical know-how, while allowing an easier career shift from proprietary software to open source.

Pocket-friendliness

In terms of cost, Novell Linux certifications like NCLP are cheaper than their Red Hat counterparts like RHCE. "While the cost of training on both is much the same, the cost of the examination is a little over Rs 10,000 for RHCE, and around Rs 6,000 for the NCLA and NCLP together," says Prasad, an RHCE, NCLA, NCLP, and a Data Centre Advanced Technical Specialist (DCATS) certified professional.

Market value

Red Hat, being more widely known, has an edge over Novell certifications. With about 50,000 certified professionals in India alone, Red Hat certifications like RHCE are likely to be more accepted than their Novell equivalents. "Most servers using Linux in India use the Red Hat flavour—Fedora. Linux has almost become synonymous with Red Hat in India. SUSE is less widely used. Thus, Red Hat certifications like RHCE have become a prerequisite when companies are hiring professionals for opportunities related to open source," says Niraj Sahay, a systems administrator with a publication house.

"As of today, the market value of Red Hat is so good that the industry presumes that a fresher with RHCE can be appointed as a Linux systems administrator (in the junior position)," says Baskar K, who is an RHCE, NCLP and ZCE (Zend Certified Engineer). Sreeram Vasudevan, an RHCE working with a Mumbai-headquartered software services and consulting company, adds: "RHCE is a nice starter, as it deals with Linux server implementation in practical scenarios. The implementation of Red Hat servers is far more widespread than Novell. Thus, Red Hat certifications



"Since the RHCE is multi-skilled on systems, networks and security parameters, certification from Red Hat is valued the highest in India."

—Sudhir Bhaskaran, head, global learning services (GLS), Red Hat



"Novell certifications make a professional more adaptable in mixed-environment scenarios, where cross-functional ability and interoperability are key to career progression."

—Sandeep Menon, country head, Novell India